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ONLINE VIDEO GAME INFLUENCER'S CREDIBILITY AND PURCHASE INTENTION

Smith BOONCHUTIMA, Aniwat SANKOSIK
Faculty of Communication Arts,
Chulalongkorn University, Bangkok, Thailand

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In the last few years, and especially during the COVID-19 pandemic, the majority of everyday activities were shifted online. Therefore, marketing strategies had to adapt to this shift. This led to the development of new forms of marketing, including influencer marketing. Although credibility is often theorised as the reason why the audience prefers to follow influencers over celebrities, empirical evidence is mixed and unrelated to the gaming industry. Therefore, our aim in this study was to test if source credibility (and its three elements: attractiveness, trustworthiness, and expertise) predicts video games purchase intentions, as well as to check if the model misspecifications caused by ignored links of causality led to inconsistent conclusions in earlier studies. The results based on an international sample of PewDiePie's followers ($N = 238$) have confirmed both ideas: source credibility predicts purchase intentions and model misspecifications of source credibility could have led to inaccurate estimates in earlier studies.

Keywords: source credibility, purchase intentions, attractiveness, trustworthiness, expertise



Smith Boonchutima, Chulalongkorn University, Faculty of Communication Arts, Department of Public Relations, 254 Phayathai Road, Pathumwan District, Wang Mai Subdistrict, Bangkok 10330, Thailand.
E-mail: smith.b@chula.ac.th

INTRODUCTION

As of January 2021, there are reportedly 4.2 billion active users of social media (Kemp, 2021). This means 4.2 billion people actively scrolling through varieties of online contents, some of which may include promotional materials. The majority of

large social media platforms have incorporated at least some form of marketing in order to enhance profits. This also allowed marketers to find new paths to the audience. According to Tuten (2020), in order to reach the audience, marketers have adapted their strategies and, in line with the contemporary trends, allocated their resources to online marketing.

One of the currently most popular methods of social media marketing is influencer marketing. Influencers, social media stars, or micro-celebrities (Gaenssle & Budzinski, 2020) are individuals who became famous by expressing their opinions and experiences online. Compared to celebrities, influencers are perceived as more credible, closer to the audience, and easier to identify with, leading to a higher efficacy of influencer marketing (Jin et al., 2019; Schouten et al., 2019). After recognising the capacity of their opinions to influence the audience through increasing brand awareness via electronic word-of-mouth (Weisfeld-Spolter et al., 2014), many marketers turned to online influencers to market their products (Hudders et al., 2021; Ki et al., 2020; Tuten, 2020). Currently, there are many forms of sponsorship, advertisement, and deals between influencers and brands, implying that influencer marketing has grown to be a vast and competitive industry that demands marketers to keep up with the ever-changing landscape (Hudders et al., 2021). As Taylor (2020) described, influencer marketing emerged as a significant subject during the COVID-19 pandemic, implying the need to study the subject more thoroughly instead of focusing solely on conversion rates.

One aspect of contemporary online industries where influencer marketing is used, but understudied, is the gaming industry (Sirola et al., 2020), one of the biggest modern online entertainment industries (Richter, 2020). Twitch.tv, to name one of many famous sites that allow live streaming of gameplay, had 15 million unique visitors daily in 2018 and about two million unique streamers monthly (Woodcock & Johnson, 2019). According to Clement (2021), the gaming market worldwide in 2020 was worth about 175 billion USD. For comparison, global box office revenue in 2019 was about 42 billion dollars and about 12 billion USD in 2020 (McClintock, 2011), which well describes the popularity of gaming. As Törhönen et al. (2020) discussed, gaming influencers can affect the audience in two ways: they can create the need to play some game and provide relevant information on the game. Also, as Canossa et al. (2019) described, video game influencers can impact the gameplay habits of their followers, including their decisions on purchasing specific game-related items using real money. The popularity of online video game influencers in some cultures

is so high that it became one of the most popular occupations among children (The LEGO group, 2019). However, the part that explains why users follow gaming influencers and their recommendations and how they choose whom to follow in the first place remain understudied. A potential answer to this question may lie in the concept of source credibility, which was in the focus of this study.

While developing the research design for this study, we aimed to offer multiple contributions to the existing literature by closing potential evidence gaps in the earlier studies. Firstly, it addresses the role of source credibility in defining purchase intentions in the context of the gaming industry, where it has not been studied before. Although it is known that E-WOM affects purchase decisions regarding video games, especially if the games are not very popular and the sources are (Zhu & Zhang, 2010), we failed to find any empirical test of the role of source credibility in the field of video game purchase. As such, it provides a valuable contribution in the form of testing the validity of generalising outcomes of earlier studies on the relationship between credibility and purchase intentions in the context of the gaming industry and influencers. Secondly, we tested multiple models in order to ensure the robustness of its findings. This is relevant because source credibility consists of multiple correlated components (Ohanian, 1990; see Literature review), which may result in biased estimates of the contribution of each component. We believed both of these contributions represent valuable information that can be used in the development of marketing strategies.

Literature review

Credibility, by definition, is the evaluation of trust and believability, with the credibility of a communicator or message source representing a relevant factor of persuasion (Hovland & Weiss, 1951). Ohanian (1990) outlines a source credibility model that includes three main underlying dimensions of source credibility – Attractiveness, Trustworthiness, and Expertise – representing characteristics or traits of sources.

Attractiveness represents a characteristic of influencers that allows them to attract attention and entertain their audience. According to Joseph (1982), attractive sources are likely to receive greater attention than those that lack them. While Ohanian (1990) and Ermeç Sertoglu et al. (2014) focused dominantly on physical attractiveness, others (e.g., McGee & Shevlin, 2009; Tornquist & Chiappe, 2015) pointed out that attractiveness goes beyond physical appearance and includes other factors, like humour and the ability to entertain others.

Trustworthiness expresses the source's capability to convey information believably to its receiver, or the extent to which the receiver perceives the source as honest, sincere, or truthful (Giffin, 1967). This can define the degree of confidence in and acceptance of the speaker's message (Sallam & Wahid, 2012). Ohanian (1990) explains that a trustworthy communicator must possess persuasive qualities while expressing a certain level of integrity. It is worth noting that trustworthiness is unrelated to the actual facts one is exhibiting – it is dominantly based on the impression the source of information makes on the audience.

Expertise is the degree of experience and qualification which determines how knowledgeable the source is (Lou & Yuan, 2019). According to Ohanian (1990), users will give their source a high level of credibility based on the ability of the source to express that they are knowledgeable in that specific area. Expertise in subject matter is important to credibility since it reflects how professional or well-informed influencers are and, therefore, worthy of being opinion leaders. According to Balog et al. (2008), influencers' success is based on their dedication to particular interests and developing expertise in that area.

Multiple studies tested the role of source credibility in purchase intentions. Generally, Harmon and Coney (1982), based on a sample of 200 business people from Phoenix, claimed that the high credibility of the source would increase the probability of purchase intention by the receiver. Many researchers focused on the credibility of celebrities (e.g., Apejoye, 2013; Ahmed et al., 2014; Pornpitaktan, 2004) and provided evidence in favour of the relevance of source credibility. Although one might be tempted to treat influencers the same as celebrities, one study found that people were more likely to trust influencers and felt closer to them compared to celebrities (Schouten et al., 2020). In the following brief review, we focused on research that studied the Ohanian (1990) model of source credibility.

Pikas et al. (2012) collected a student sample and asked them about the perceived relevance of three components of source credibility in various purchase situations. Although the majority of participants pointed out source attractiveness as the most relevant characteristic, relevance of the three source credibility components varied with respect to purchase conditions. Two additional characteristics of this study should be noticed: the responses were ipsative, indicating that choosing one aspect as relevant does not mean that the others are irrelevant, and in all conditions at least some fraction of participants recognised the role of each factor. In the context of social networks, Gunawan and Huarng (2015) collected a snowball

sample from various online spaces and found that source credibility, along with argument quality, determines attitudes towards information which, in turn, predict purchase behaviour. Lim et al. (2017) collected a convenient sample of Malaysian students with a similar purpose. They found that source attractiveness had an indirect effect on purchase intention, while no arguments in favour of the relationship between source credibility (defined through expertise and trustworthiness) and purchase intention were found. Although the study mentions a structural model, it is not shown in the manuscript, implying that the absence of effect might be a consequence of overcontrolling that opened some backdoor paths (see Cinelli et al., 2020) or multicollinearity, which is highly plausible considering Table 3 (Lim et al., 2017, p. 29). One study used a convenient sample of dominantly college students and found that beauty vlogs endorsed purchase intentions among users who already had experience with the product (Sekarasih et al., 2017). In that study, with a relatively low statistical power, previous experience emerged as a more relevant predictor of purchase intentions compared to source credibility. However, the absence of the correlation table again prevents the conclusion that this absence of significant effects is not another example of "bad controls" (Cinelli et al., 2020).

This study

The presented studies imply several conclusions. Firstly, their operationalisation of source credibility varied in terms of the elements that were included in the concept, which could have led to variable results. Secondly, this can be further explained by potentially sub-optimal structural models used in some of the studies, which led to overcontrolling. In this study, we attempted to rectify this and tested the Ohanian (1990) model of source credibility in the context of predicting video-game purchase intentions.

In order to operationalise our expectations, we formed multiple hypotheses. In line with the previous literature (Gunawan & Huarng, 2015; Lim et al., 2017; Pikas et al., 2012), we expected to establish a positive relationship between source credibility and purchase intentions (H1). Taking into account the potential limitations of statistical procedures used in this study, we calculated separate models with and without credibility as the second-order factor and further specified this hypothesis. Firstly, in the model with credibility as the second-order factor, we expected to find that all three first-order factors (attractiveness, trustworthiness, and expertise) are substantially loaded on the second-order factor of credibility (H1a) and that this second-order factor significantly predicts

purchase intentions (H1b). However, in the model with no second-order factor of credibility, we expected to find only one of the three first-order factors as a significant predictor of purchase intentions (H1c).

Before testing such a hypothesis, one has to determine a relevant source of information whose credibility will be assessed. According to Tankovska (2021), one of the most popular video game online influencers on Youtube, named PewDiePie, currently has more than 27 billion views on his YouTube channel. PewDiePie is one of the influencers that popularised video game content on YouTube, resulting in gaming content becoming one of the most-watched contents on online platforms. Due to his huge success (Drehs, 2015), we decided to use him as a source and tested the relationship between his credibility and the purchase intentions of his followers.

METHODS

Participants

Of 414 respondents recruited via social media sites, data cleaning left us with 238 participants (77.3% men). The average participant was born between 1998 and 1999, implying that he or she was approximately 21 to 22 years old when the study was conducted. On average, they watched PewDiePie's videos for over four years ($M = 4.29$) and played video games for more than five hours a week ($M = 5.45$).

Measures

This section briefly presents the measures used in this study. All the items were measured on 1-5 scales, with higher values indicating higher levels of the measured constructs.¹

The questions used to measure source credibility were developed based on Ohanian's (1990) and Ermeç Sertoglu et al.'s (2014) studies. Attractiveness was measured using three items ("Do you find PewDiePie physically attractive", "Do you find PewDiePie funny to watch", and "Do you find PewDiePie entertaining to watch"), which formed a single factor with acceptable internal consistency ($\alpha = 0.75$). Trustworthiness was measured using four items ("Do you find PewDiePie honest towards viewers?", "Do you find PewDiePie trustworthy when it comes to his opinion on video games?", "Do you find PewDiePie relatable?", and "Do you find PewDiePie's opinion of video games similar to yours?"), also forming a single factor with acceptable internal consistency ($\alpha = 0.77$). Expertise was measured with only two items ("Do you think that PewDiePie is good at video games generally?" and "Do you think PewDiePie has a lot of experience in video games?"), which makes it, in

the context of this study, more of a formative than reflective construct and explains a somewhat lower internal consistency of the scale ($\alpha = 0.46$).

Purchase intention was measured using three items developed for the purposes of this study ("I am likely to purchase a video game product based on PewDiePie's opinions", "I am likely to be interested in buying certain video games if PewDiePie plays them or talks about them", and "I am likely to be interested in video game products sponsored by PewDiePie"). They formed a scale with a high internal consistency ($\alpha = 0.86$).

Of control variables, we also measured the age (as birth year) and gender of participants. We also included five questions regarding the gaming activities of participants: two related to the weekly quantity of gaming and length of following PewDiePie's videos, and three that served as filter questions ("Do you watch PewDiePie on YouTube, Twitch or any other platform?", "Do you play video games?", "Have you ever spent money on video games?").

Procedure

The ethical aspects of the study were evaluated and approved by the institutional International Programs Office. Invitations to participate in this study were disseminated online, using social media sites. After reading the text of the informed consent, which introduced participants to their rights, including the right to stop participating at any moment without consequences, participants who agreed with the terms filled the questionnaires. The filter questions on PewDiePie eliminated 79 participants. In the next step, we excluded 41 participants who failed to provide answers to all the relevant questions. From this subsample, we further eliminated 31 participants who provided the same answer more than nine times in a row due to potential careless responding. In the next step, we excluded 19 participants due to their age, which was less characteristic of typical youth (> 30). Finally, we excluded six participants due to their unusual results on the items relevant for this study, as recognised by Mahalanobis distance. This led us to the final sample of 238 participants. Based on Ohanian (1990), we expected correlations between source credibility and purchase intentions of about 0.40, which at the power of 80% requires 45 participants to be significant at $\alpha = 0.05$. However, according to Schönbrodt and Perugini (2013), it takes about 200-250 participants to achieve stable correlations, which is why we decided to collect more than 45 participants.

Analyses were conducted in R (R Core Team, 2021). The most relevant packages for analyses were lavaan (Rosseel, 2012)

and semTools (Jorgensen et al., 2021), while the complete list of packages can be found in the OSF link. SEM using robust maximum likelihood estimator was used to calculate the results.

RESULTS

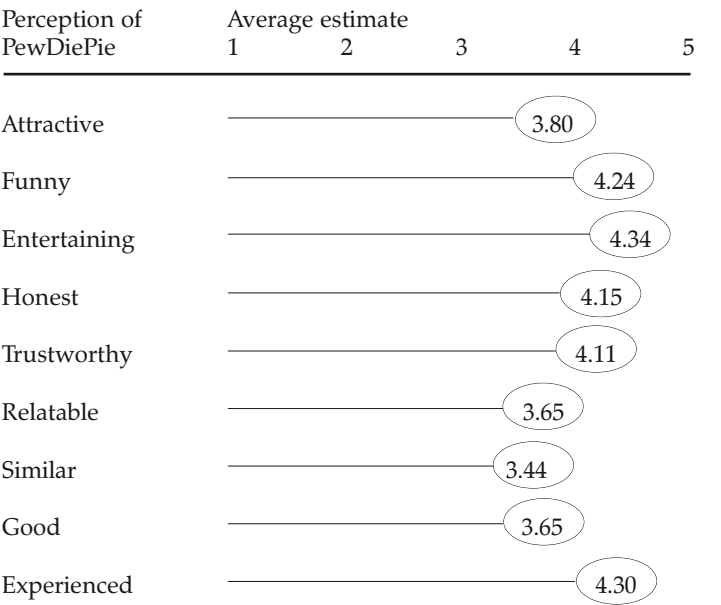
The results of the applied statistical analyses are briefly exhibited in this section.

TABLE 1
Item-wise descriptive statistics based on a sample of followers of PewDiePie (N = 238)

	M	SD	Median	IQR
Attractive	3.80	0.84	4	1
Funny	4.24	0.75	4	1
Entertaining	4.34	0.77	4	1
Honest	4.15	0.86	4	1
Trustworthy	4.11	0.80	4	1
Relatable	3.65	1.00	4	1
Similar	3.44	0.93	3	1
Good	3.65	0.85	4	1
Experienced	4.30	0.62	4	1
Purchase intentions 1	3.16	1.06	3	2
Purchase intentions 2	3.45	1.00	4	1
Purchase intentions 3	3.14	1.02	3	1

Descriptive statistics exhibited in Table 1 suggest that participants had a generally positive opinion on PewDiePie, as all the average estimates (and majority of medians) were slightly above the midpoint of the scale. Exhibited variability in opinions is somewhat low, but it should suffice for valid outputs of statistical analyses.

FIGURE 1
Perception of PewDiePie in a convenient youth sample (N = 238)



The averages presented in Figure 1 suggest that participants generally had a positive opinion on PewDiePie's credibility. They dominantly considered him funny, entertaining, experienced, and honest, while his choice of video games they generally found relatable. Regarding purchase intentions, participants were, on average, neutral regarding following PewDiePie's recommendations (means ranging from 3.14 for interest in games that PewDiePie sponsors to 3.45 for the likelihood of buying games if PewDiePie talks about them or plays them).

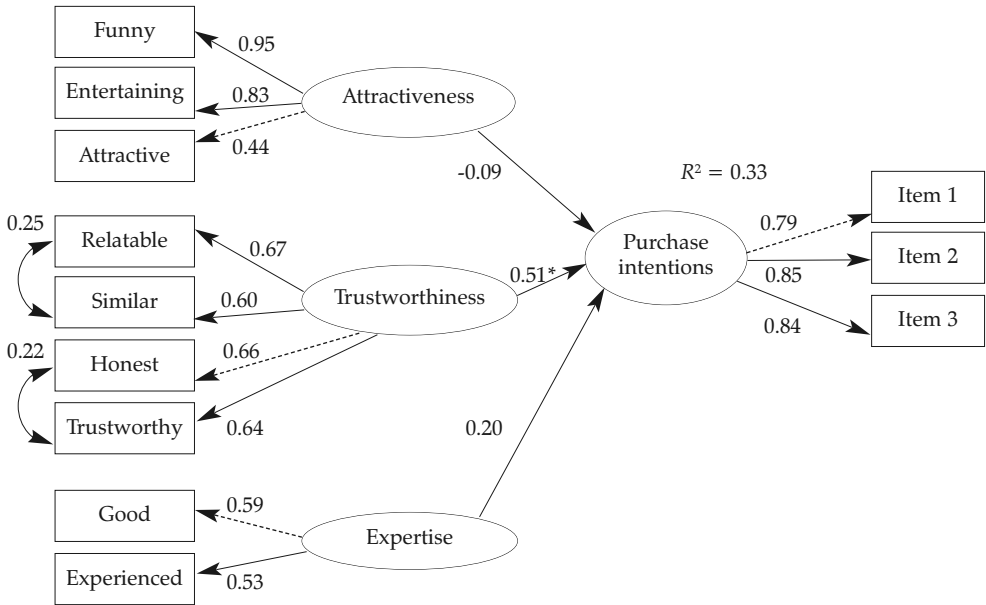
TABLE 2
Correlations between
source credibility and
purchase intentions

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
(1) Attractiveness	1				
(2) Trustworthiness	0.80*	1			
(3) Expertise	0.52*	0.58*	1		
(4) Credibility	0.85*	0.94*	0.62*	1	
(5) Purchase	0.46*	0.51*	0.33*	0.54*	1

* $p < 0.001$

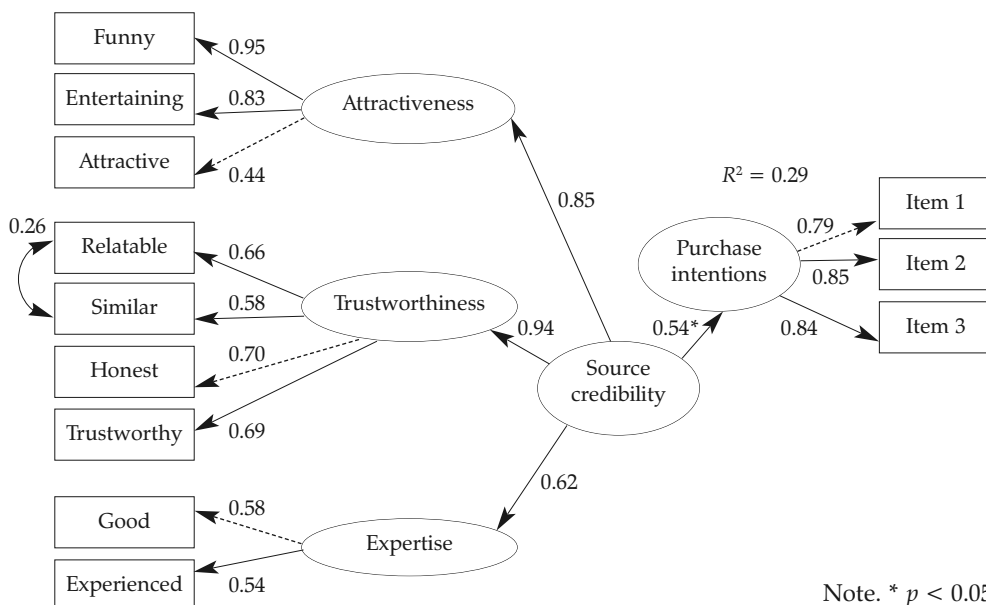
FIGURE 2
Source credibility
elements as distinct
constructs in the
prediction of video
game purchase
intentions

The correlation table (Table 2) shows that all the elements of source credibility, as well as the general component of credibility, are positively related to purchase intentions. This means that participants who considered PewDiePie more credible (and, specifically, more attractive, trustworthy, and expert) were also more likely to follow his advice on video game purchases.



Note. * $p < 0.05$.

FIGURE 3
Source credibility
in the prediction of
video game purchase
intentions



We repeated these analyses with age and gender as additional predictors of purchase intentions and obtained nearly identical results.

DISCUSSION

The results of this study confirmed the researchers' expectations. In general (and in line with H1), the study found moderate to strong positive relationships between source credibility and video game purchase intentions. This is in line with other studies (Harmon & Coney, 1982; Ohanian, 1990; Pornpitakdan, 2004) that established such relationships in other purchasing contexts. Influencers who may seem ordinary and approachable (Chapple & Crownie, 2017), but knowledgeable (Erz & Heeris Christiansen, 2018) and willing to entertain their audience (Ermeç Sertoglu et al., 2014) seem to be considered as

credible. Our model achieved adequate fit despite joining variables of engagement, defined as how fun to watch and entertaining the presenter was (Todd & Melacon, 2018), and attractiveness. These findings are in line with Eisend (2006): attractiveness seems to have a broader meaning. It does not reflect only the visual characteristics but also the level of engagement and emotional arousal that a person can invoke, which, in the proper context, can enhance memory of the content (Mather, 2007). Altogether, it seems like credible sources of information and their recommendations on video games are more likely to be followed when making purchase decisions than less credible ones.

Next to confirming the relationship between source credibility and purchase intentions, this study also addressed some limitations of the earlier literature – mainly, the issue of "bad controls" (Cinelli et al., 2020). In line with H1a and H1b, first-order factors of credibility according to Ohanian's (1990) model substantially loaded on the general factor, and this general factor predicted purchase intentions fairly well. In line with H1c, the absence of the second-order factor led to less consistent results – only one first-order factor (trustworthiness) was established as a significant predictor of purchase intentions. The discrepancy in the results of available literature may stem from the specific analytical approaches. Namely, multiple studies included all three elements of source credibility in the regression models at the same time. Although some controlled for variance inflation due to their intercorrelation (Lim et al., 2017), the potential causal links between the three predictors were not addressed. As Cinelli et al. (2020) discuss, if relationships between multiple predictors are uncertain, their joint inclusion in the same model may lead to less precise estimates of their effects instead of more precise ones, which the inclusion of control factors should yield. For instance, the latter authors discuss that the inclusion of a mediator as a control factor could undermine the estimate of the direct effect of a predictor on a criterion. Unfortunately, until now, researchers did not focus on addressing the potential causal relationships between the three factors of source credibility. For instance, Palmer and Peterson (2015) have shown that, in the context of political expertise, more attractive individuals are often perceived as more knowledgeable and persuasive. Furthermore, a recent study found that the relationship between cheerfulness in scientific communication and the perception of comedy as a relevant source of scientific information was partially mediated by perceived expertise, which was strongly correlated with perceived likeability (Yeo et al., 2020). Therefore, although one might hypothesise on causal relationships between perceived attractiveness and perceived expertise, Oha-

nian's (1990) model does not take that into account. The potential misspecifications of statistical models described in the previous section may have some theoretical implications, as well. The formation of an overarching theory seems to be the next step in resolving the relationships between specific aspects of source credibility and the prediction of purchase intentions.

Next to discerning the relationships within the source credibility model, researchers should also focus on determining the position of this model within larger theoretical frameworks. One such potential framework could be the theory of planned behaviour (Ajzen, 1991). According to Ajzen (1991), behavioural intentions, which directly predict behaviours, are a consequence of attitudes on the issue, subjective norms (i.e., beliefs of other relevant individuals related to the issue), and perceived behavioural control (i.e., the extent to which an individual perceives himself or herself as the one in control of executing that behaviour). In online environments, one can see the number of views, likes, hearts, or other indicators of positive attitudes towards specific people, attitudes, or contents. These could serve as indicators of subjective norms in multiple ways. Firstly, these indicators inform a person about whom his or her peers consider worth following – in other words, who is considered as a credible source. Furthermore, the audience can generally identify well with influencers (Schouten et al., 2020), which may serve as a confirmation of their credibility as sources when it comes to the subjects in which they are considered experts. Other researchers also included source credibility within the scope of subjective norms (see Aditami, 2016; Ajina, 2019). However, gaming influencers can, theoretically, do more than that. Gaming influencers also provide relevant information on where to find the game on a discount and what the gameplay actually looks (and feels) like (i.e., EWOM), which, in turn, may modify viewers' opinions on the subject and perceived control over purchase behaviours. Although source credibility may lead to changes in purchase intentions, the relationship might as well go the other way around: while it is plausible that less credible individuals gain credibility by endorsing popular options and opinions, endorsing unpopular opinions may undermine one's credibility, probably via undermined expertise. Altogether, although source credibility seems to be a relevant construct in purchasing behaviours, its integration with other theoretical approaches from social psychology focused on predicting (purchase) behaviours might lead to even more effective models.

Several characteristics of this study could impede the validity of generalisations of its conclusions. Firstly, the study was not based on representative data of PewDiePie's followers,

implying that the ratings of PewDiePie's characteristics may not reflect how the entire public perceives him. Secondly, this study was based on a correlational design, implying that the validity of any causal conclusion is necessarily limited. Thirdly, while the study relied on instruments based on the items of original studies (Ermeç Sertoglu et al., 2014; Ohanian, 1990), the robustness of its findings would be increased if the complete versions of scales or some other relevant scales were used. Fourthly, we used only one influencer as the relevant source, so we cannot be sure based on these results how much of the effect can be attributed to PewDiePie and how much to gaming influencers in general. Finally, the sample size prevented us from conducting multi-group analyses, which is why we had to control for age and gender.

Therefore, in future studies, next to taking potential multicollinearity into account, it might be interesting to test whether the differences between participant's and influencer's gender affects this network of constructs. In other words, multi-group analyses might contribute to the further development of this field as they would allow to test the effects of gender and congruence between viewer's and influencer's gender on the perception of credibility and purchase intentions. Additionally, experimental studies convey the most valuable information for practitioners. Therefore, in order to obtain a more precise estimate of how credibility (or some of its sub-concepts) define purchase intention, it is inevitable to conduct experiments. Although such research designs are much more complex than correlational research designs, the benefits of conducting them is worth the effort.

However, the latter argument does not mean that the results of the present study are irrelevant for practitioners. After all, there are studies that revealed the positive effect of celebrity endorsement on purchase intentions using experimental research designs (Apejoye, 2013), as well as relevance of perceiving the endorser as trustworthy (Silvera & Austad, 2004). However, our study does not allow estimation whether influencer endorsement leads to better results than celebrity endorsement as one could presume based on the presumptions that the audience prefers trusting influencers to trusting celebrities (Schouten et al., 2020). Therefore, while no arguments against influencer marketing have been provided, further studies are required to ascertain the extent of benefits of choosing influencers instead of celebrities in (video game) marketing.

Altogether, this study, taking into account the limitations of its predecessors, established that perceived source credibility is related to video game purchase intentions. However, the

internal structure of the model, as well as its placement within wider theoretical frameworks, remain unresolved. In line with the statement that every model is suboptimal, yet some can be helpful (Box, 1976), we can conclude that this model explains a substantial portion of the variance of purchase intentions despite its unresolved internal structure. This study, by resolving (at least some of) the problems with the model specification that might have led to unclear results in previous research, opens the door for future tests that could help the development and integration of this model, as well as marketing strategies that are based on it.

Anonymised link to dataset and SPSS file:

https://osf.io/2d5y6/?view_only=f340465863ac45d886a6ae6bcc194e

NOTES

¹ Although we would usually apply confirmatory factor analysis on each scale, in order to get valid results we would have to have four or more items per construct. As the majority of our constructs are operationalised using three or fewer items, the application of CFA would yield perfect, yet non-informative fit indices. This was the main reason for our deviation from the standard procedure of checking fit of each instrument prior to evaluating fit of the overall model.

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Vjerodostojnost online influencera videoigara i namjera kupnje

Smith BOONCHUTIMA, Aniwat SANKOSIK
Fakultet komunikacijskih umjetnosti, Sveučilište Chulalongkorn,
Bangkok, Tajland

U zadnje vrijeme, a posebno tijekom pandemije COVID-19, većina svakodnevnih aktivnosti premještena je na internet. Stoga su se marketinške strategije morale prilagoditi ovoj promjeni. To je dovelo do razvoja novih oblika marketinga, uključujući influencerski marketing. Iako se vjerodostojnost često teoretizira kao razlog zašto publika radije slijedi influencere nego slavne osobe, empirijski se dokazi razlikuju i nisu povezani s industrijom igara. Stoga je naš cilj u ovom radu bio ispitati predviđa li vjerodostojnost izvora (i njegova tri čimbenika: privlačnost, pouzdanost i stručnost) namjeru kupnje videoigara, kao i provjeriti jesu li pogrešne specifikacije modela uzrokovane zanemarenim uzročno-posljedičnim vezama dovele do nedosljednosti zaključaka u dosadašnjim studijama. Rezultati utemeljeni na međunarodnom uzorku PewDiePiejevih sljedbenika ($N = 238$) potvrdili su obje ideje: vjerodostojnost izvora predviđa namjere kupnje, a pogrešne specifikacije modela vjerodostojnosti izvora mogle su dovesti do netočnih procjena u dosadašnjim studijama.

Ključne riječi: vjerodostojnost izvora, namjere kupnje, privlačnost, pouzdanost, stručnost



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